



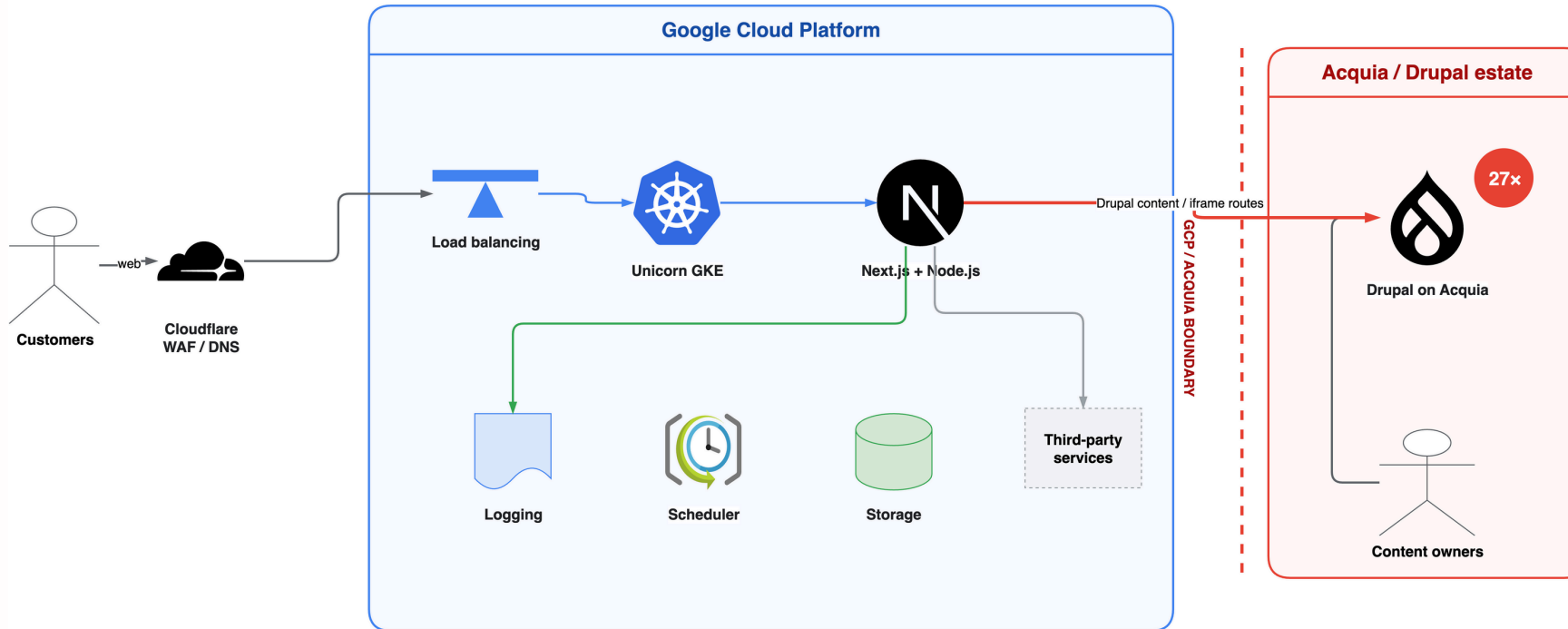
One content platform on GCP

A decision framework for replacing 27 Drupal sites with one governed content platform

Today, Next.js already serves a mix of native pages and Drupal content

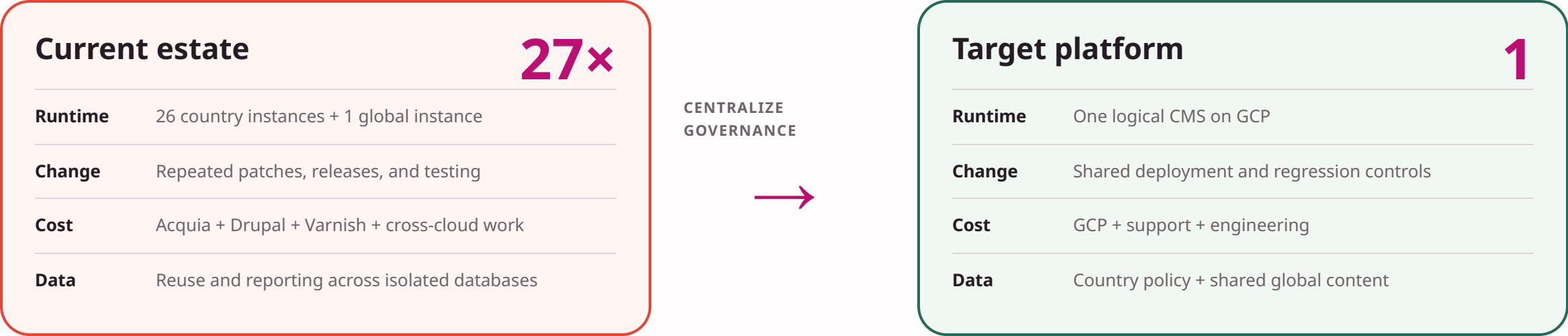
Current platform context: Next.js composes GCP and Drupal delivery

CMS delivery only: native Next.js routes and legacy Drupal / iframe routes cross the GCP / Acquia boundary directly.



Mixed delivery exists today; migration can move route ownership gradually instead of waiting for one big cutover.

Replace 27 separate CMS stacks with one governed platform



The business case comes from retiring repeated platform work across 27 stacks.

Improve publishing without weakening engineering control

01

Platform ownership

GCP, PostgreSQL, GCS, backup, and restore.

02

Global publishing

26 country sites, one global site, seven languages, and scoped access.

03

Editorial control

Draft, preview, review, approval, schedule, and translation state.

04

Structured experience

Approved blocks and rich text—not arbitrary styling.

05

Digital operations

Forms, SEO, audit, observability, and environment promotion.

06

Productivity + transition

Enterprise AI, support, and a controlled Drupal coexistence period.

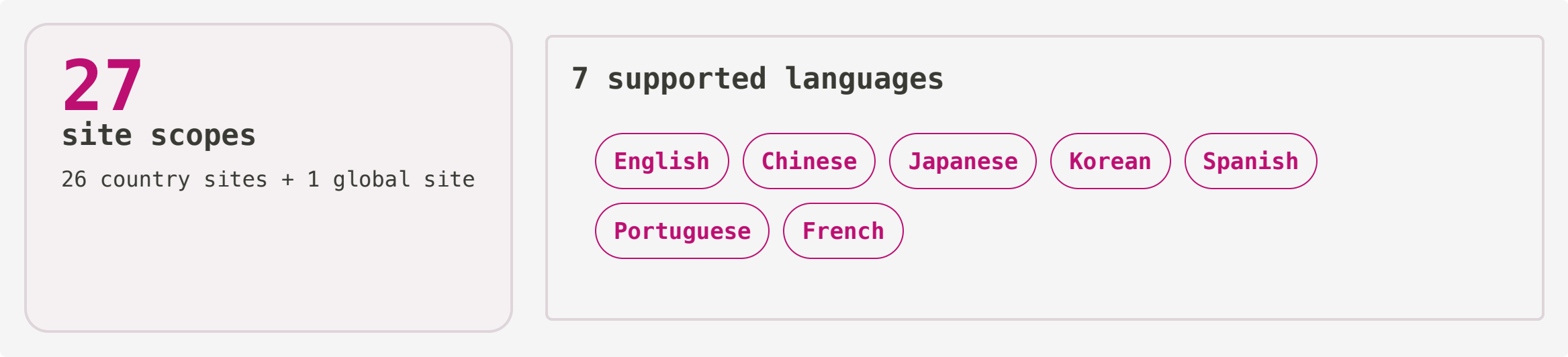
These six outcomes define the minimum acceptable platform.

Both candidates meet the technical baseline; team fit and operating model decide

Decision area	Payload	Directus
Self-host, PostgreSQL, GCS	Strong	Strong
Next.js / TypeScript fit	Native-strength fit	Strong API/SDK fit
Admin extension stack	React	Vue
Multi-country model	Official multi-tenant plugin + code	Row-level policy or project scoping
Publishing workflow	Packaged multi-step approvals + feedback	Native drafts/versions; custom approvals
Headless forms	Official Form Builder	Collections + frontend + Flows
Environment promotion	Code + migrations; reference-data tooling needed	v12.3 Environment Sync
Audit	Enterprise Activity Logs + revisions	Activity Log + revisions
AI productivity	Translation + image + writing + MCP	Assistant + translation + MCP + custom LLM
A/B testing	Enterprise static headless variants	Custom model + feature-flag/analytics service
Commercial model	MIT self-hosted core; Enterprise custom quote	MSCL; Enterprise custom quote

Both are viable; Payload aligns more directly with our Next.js, React, and TypeScript operating model.

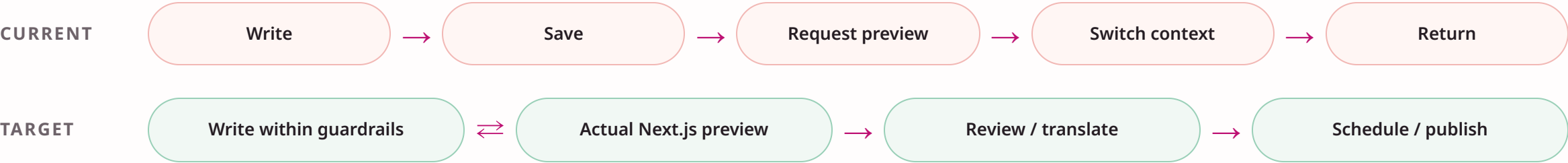
Example: 26 country sites and one global site can share seven languages



Global site Example: publish all seven languages	Japan site Example: Japanese + English	Korea site Example: Korean + English
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A country site defines ownership and access. Language is a separate publishing choice.

Give editors live preview while they write



Continuous preview

Preview stays inside the writing flow

Role-shaped flow

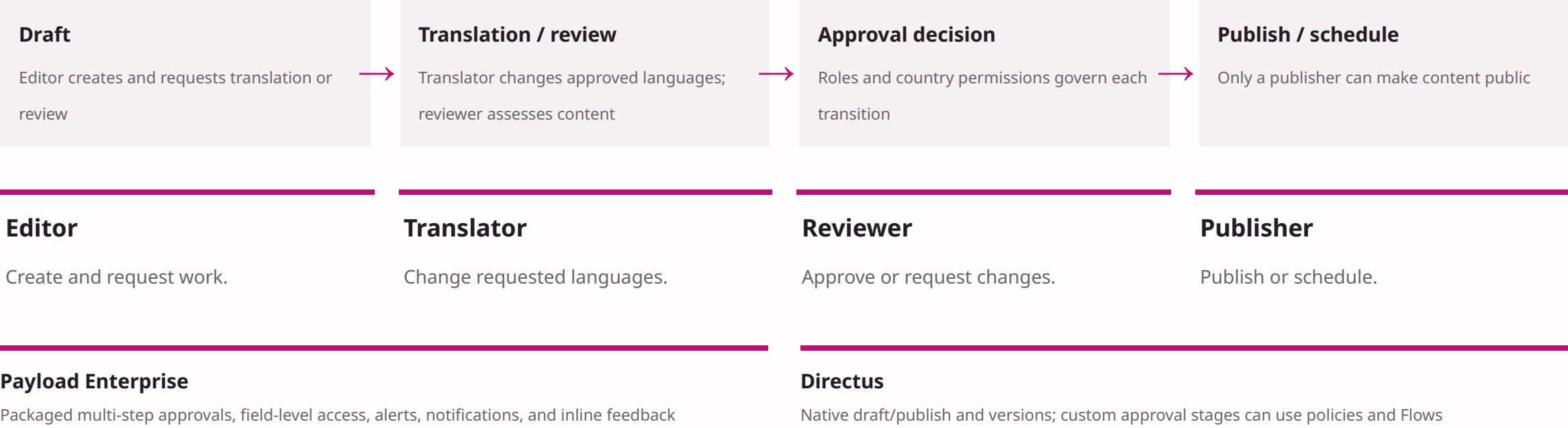
Review, translation, approval, schedule

Governed creation

Approved blocks, forms, and human-reviewed Enterprise AI

The target makes daily publishing faster, clearer, and easier for content teams.

Make approval, translation, and publishing rules visible and enforceable



Payload packages the approval capabilities we need; Directus requires more workflow configuration.

Publish with control, then improve with governed A/B testing

Payload Enterprise

Packaged headless experimentation

Editors manage approved variants in the CMS. Next.js can statically deliver them from the edge, avoiding client-side flicker while analytics remain pluggable.

Directus

Composable experimentation

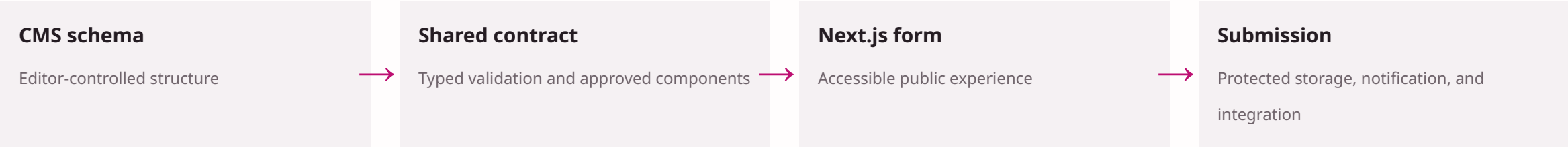
Experiments and variants can be modeled in Directus and connected to PostHog or another feature-flag and analytics service.

Govern Only approved content blocks and variants	Measure One primary metric plus guardrails	Protect Consent, audience, accessibility, and audit controls	Stop Defined end conditions and rapid rollback
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Payload packages variant management and static delivery, reducing implementation effort for our Next.js platform.

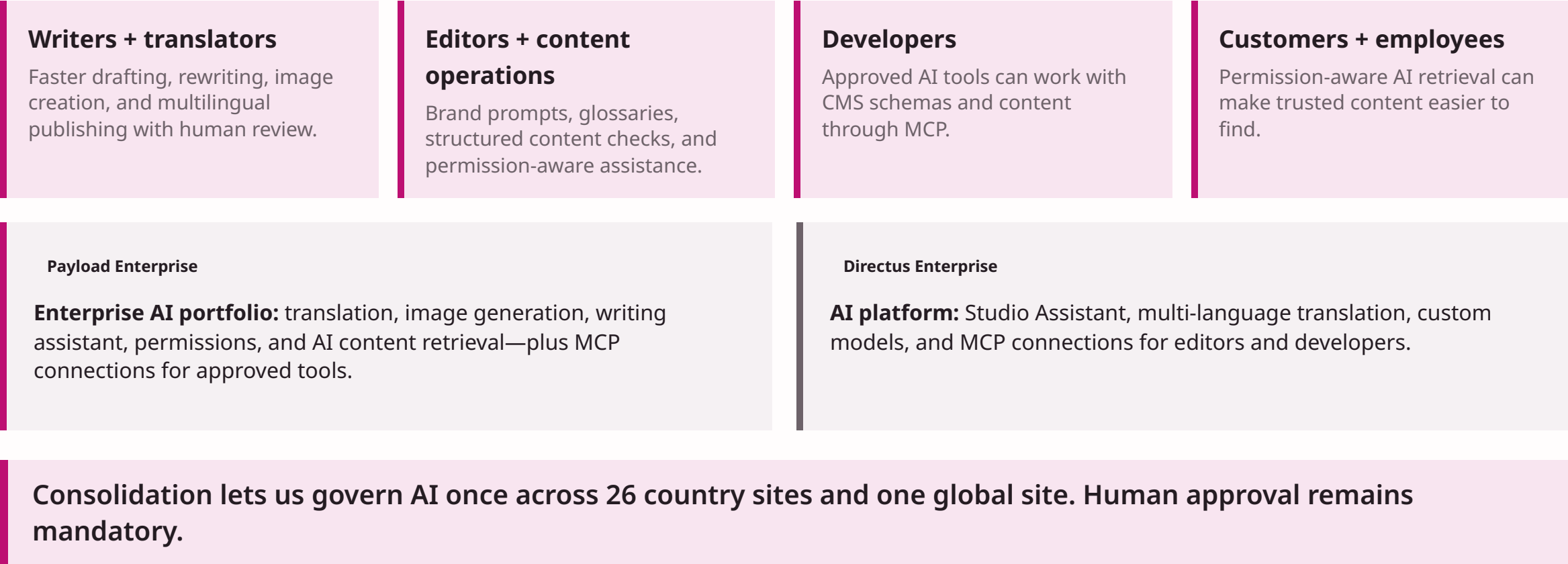
Payload leads on headless forms; Directus leads on visual automation

Requirement	Payload	Directus
Editors define schema	Official Form Builder	Model collections or build extension
Next.js uses our components	Designed for frontend mapping	Custom frontend pattern
Store and manage submissions	Yes	Yes
Notifications + workflow	Emails + custom hooks	Flows are strong
File upload	Supported	Supported through files/API
Conditional / multi-step	Requires validation	Custom implementation
Consent, spam, retention, PII	Our production controls	Our production controls



A representative complex form will confirm conditional logic, consent, uploads, notifications, and retention.

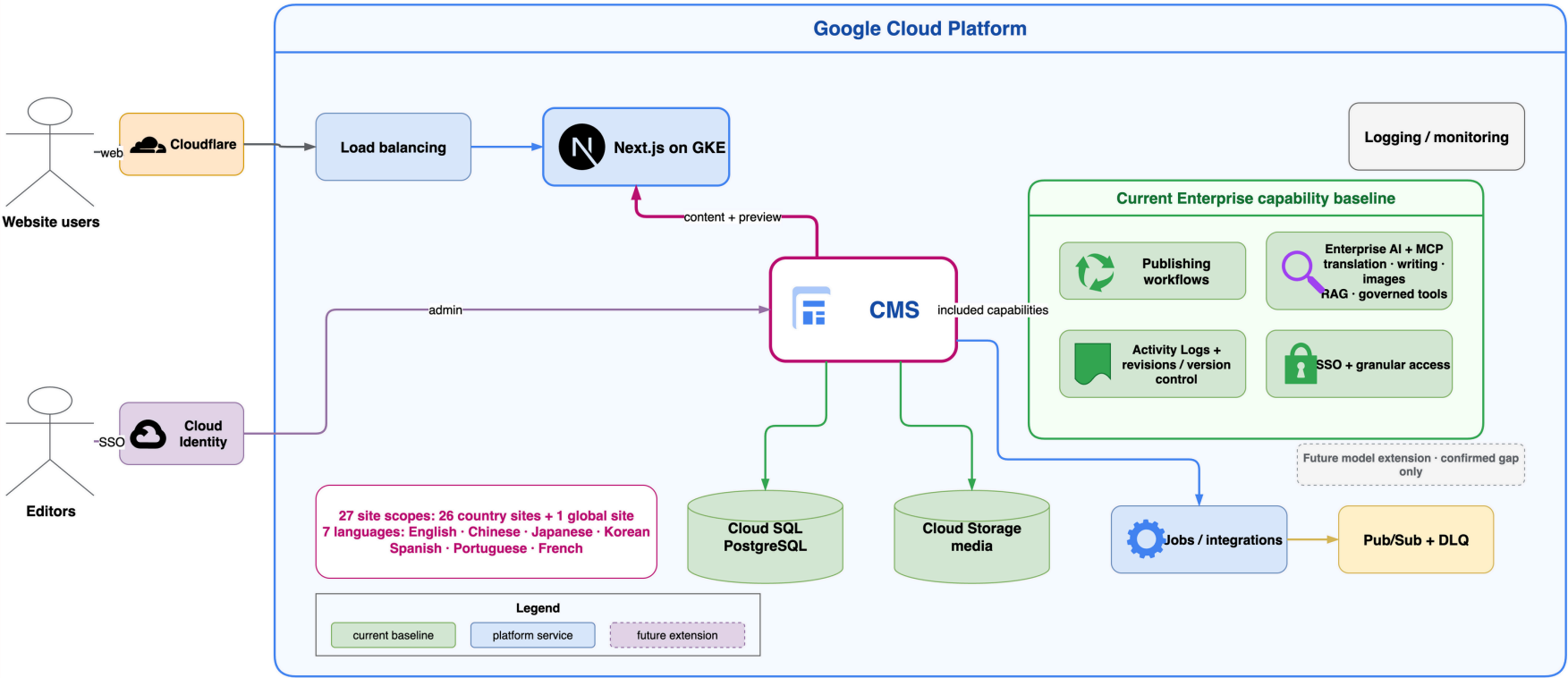
Enterprise AI improves content operations across the organization



One CMS can govern 26 country sites and one global site without 27 runtimes

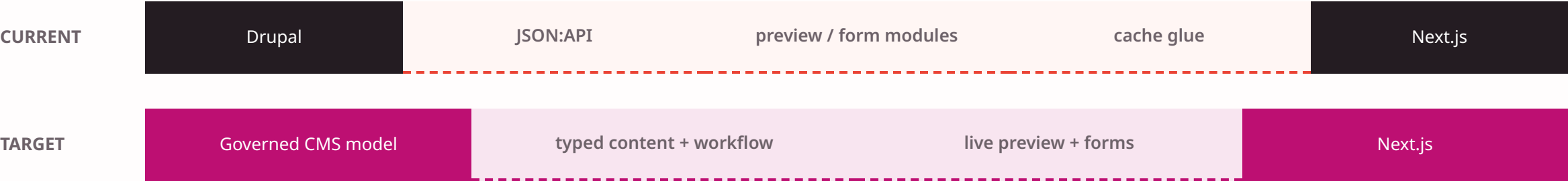
Target: one governed CMS with Enterprise capabilities on GCP

Enterprise AI, MCP, workflow, and audit serve 26 country sites plus one global site from one governed platform.



Country ownership and language choice remain independent.

Turn repeated headless integration into shared platform capability



Drafts

Application-aware preview reads

Translation

Per-language status and source tracking

Preview

Actual website components

Forms

Schema mapped to governed UI

Drupal supports headless delivery; the cost is repeating and maintaining the surrounding integration across 27 instances.

Bring CMS customization into our TypeScript engineering model

CURRENT CUSTOMIZATION

Drupal + PHP modules

separate types · UI · tests · telemetry

Acquia operations

VERSUS

TARGET CUSTOMIZATION

CMS schema + hooks + jobs

Extensible Admin UI + shared design system

TypeScript tests + GCP telemetry

The opportunity is one engineering model for the website, CMS, tests, and operations.

Promote code, govern content, and prove recovery with the right controls

Schema + configuration	Versioned changes provide consistent, reviewable promotion across environments.
Content + reference data	Editorial content stays in production. Countries, taxonomies, templates, and controlled defaults use versioned export/diff/import. PII is sanitized before lower environments.
Audit + recovery	Activity history, revisions, retention, export, SIEM integration, site scope, and database-plus-media recovery.

Platform capability and operating controls together provide reliable promotion, audit, and recovery.

Directus sets a high bar for editorial foundations and AI capability

Environment Sync

Pull, diff, and push schema, settings, roles, policies, permissions, Flows, and dashboards as JSON.

Editorial foundation

Native draft/publish and content versions are strong; approval stages can be composed with policies and Flows.

Audit

Built-in Activity Log plus item revisions and reversion.

AI productivity

Studio Assistant supports content and schema work; translation and MCP extend it across editor and developer workflows.

Business value

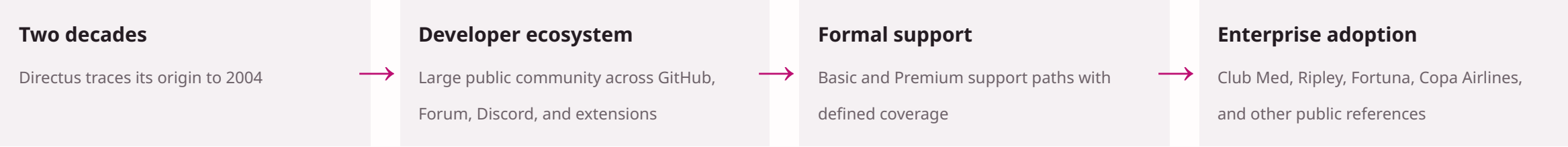
It reduces custom work in areas content teams will notice immediately.

Implementation considerations

Approval workflows, static A/B testing, and headless forms require more configuration and integration than Payload.

Directus establishes a strong benchmark for editorial experience and content operations.

Directus is a credible enterprise platform



Community channels

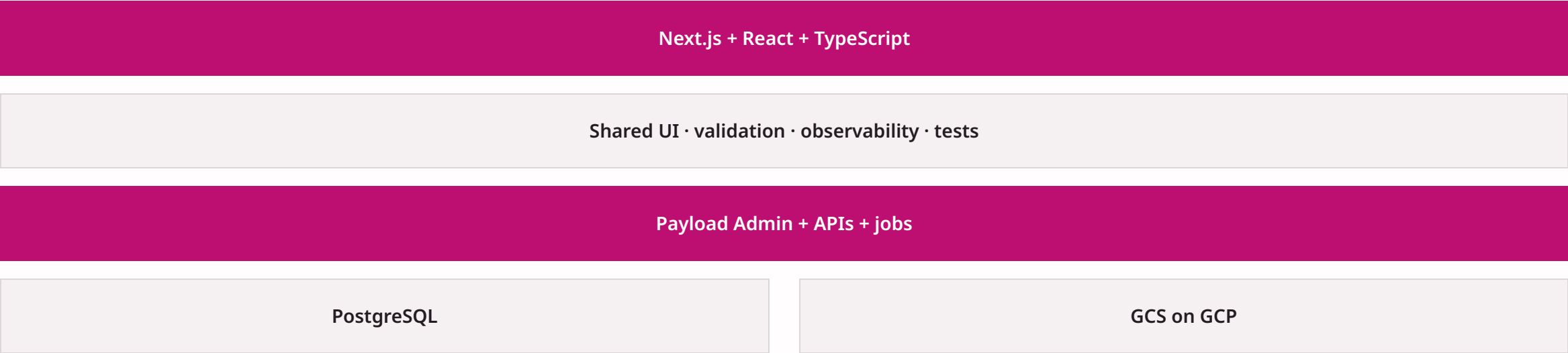
Forum, Discord live chat, GitHub Issues, and a public roadmap.

Commercial model

Source-available under MSCL; enterprise licensing and support terms are part of the decision.

Directus remains credible; differentiation rests on stack fit, forms, workflow, experimentation, and licensing.

Payload aligns with our Next.js, React, TypeScript, and GCP model



Govern publishing

Start with packaged approvals, notifications, feedback, and field-level access; extend only ONE-specific policy.

Optimize safely

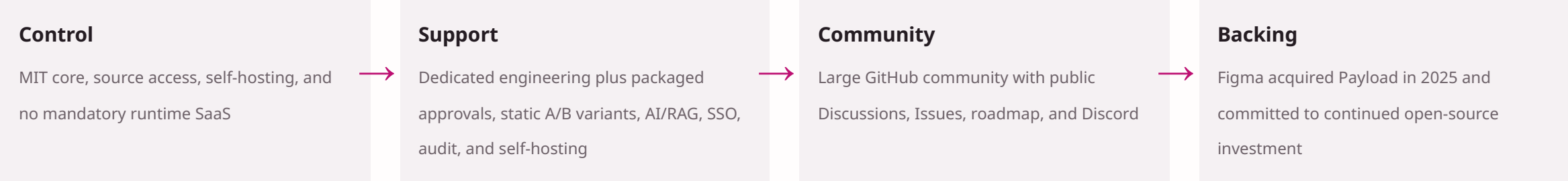
Manage A/B variants in the CMS and deliver them statically through Next.js with approved analytics.

Use one engineering model

Workflow, experiments, AI, policy, migrations, and Admin UI remain reviewable TypeScript/React work.

Payload brings CMS work into our established application engineering model.

Payload combines open-source control with Enterprise support



Enterprise adoption

Public customer references include Microsoft, Mazda, ASICS, Blue Origin, Sonos, and other global organizations.

Enterprise assurance

The enterprise agreement will define SLA, escalation, upgrade support, feature scope, and self-hosting guarantees.

Open source and Enterprise support together reduce exit and operating risk.

Recommend Payload for the strongest fit across content, engineering, and ownership

Both platforms meet the enterprise CMS baseline. Payload requires less adaptation in the areas that define ONE's long-term operating model.

Better content operations

Enterprise publishing workflows, static A/B testing, AI-assisted writing, translation and image generation, plus an official headless Form Builder.

One engineering model

Next.js, React, and TypeScript align the CMS, Admin extensions, design system, tests, migration logic, and day-to-day development.

Long-term control

GCP self-hosting, PostgreSQL, GCS, an MIT-licensed core, activity logs, revisions, and Enterprise support keep the platform governable and replaceable.

Directus remains credible

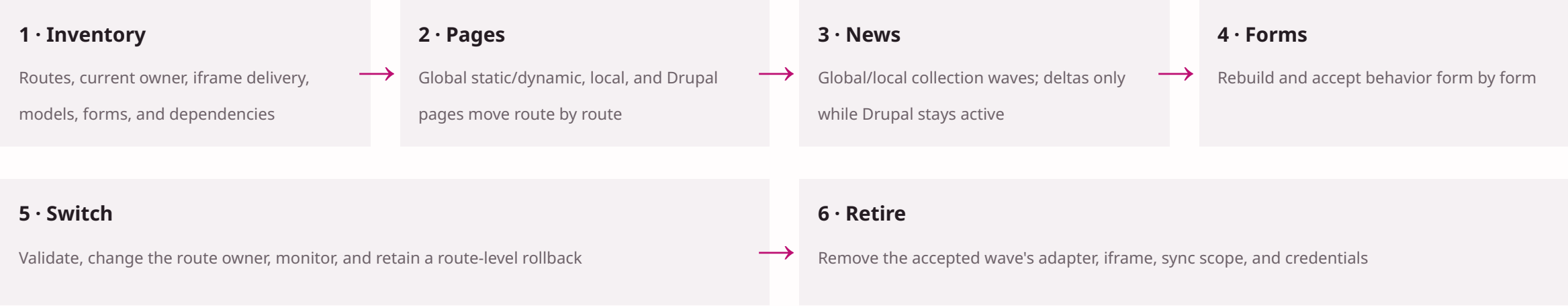
It leads in packaged Environment Sync and offers mature Studio automation, Flows, AI, and broad data-platform flexibility.

The deciding difference

Payload combines comparable Enterprise authoring capability with a materially stronger fit for how ONE builds and owns digital products.

Directus is a strong option; Payload is the better long-term fit for ONE.

Migrate by route and content group while both CMSs remain available

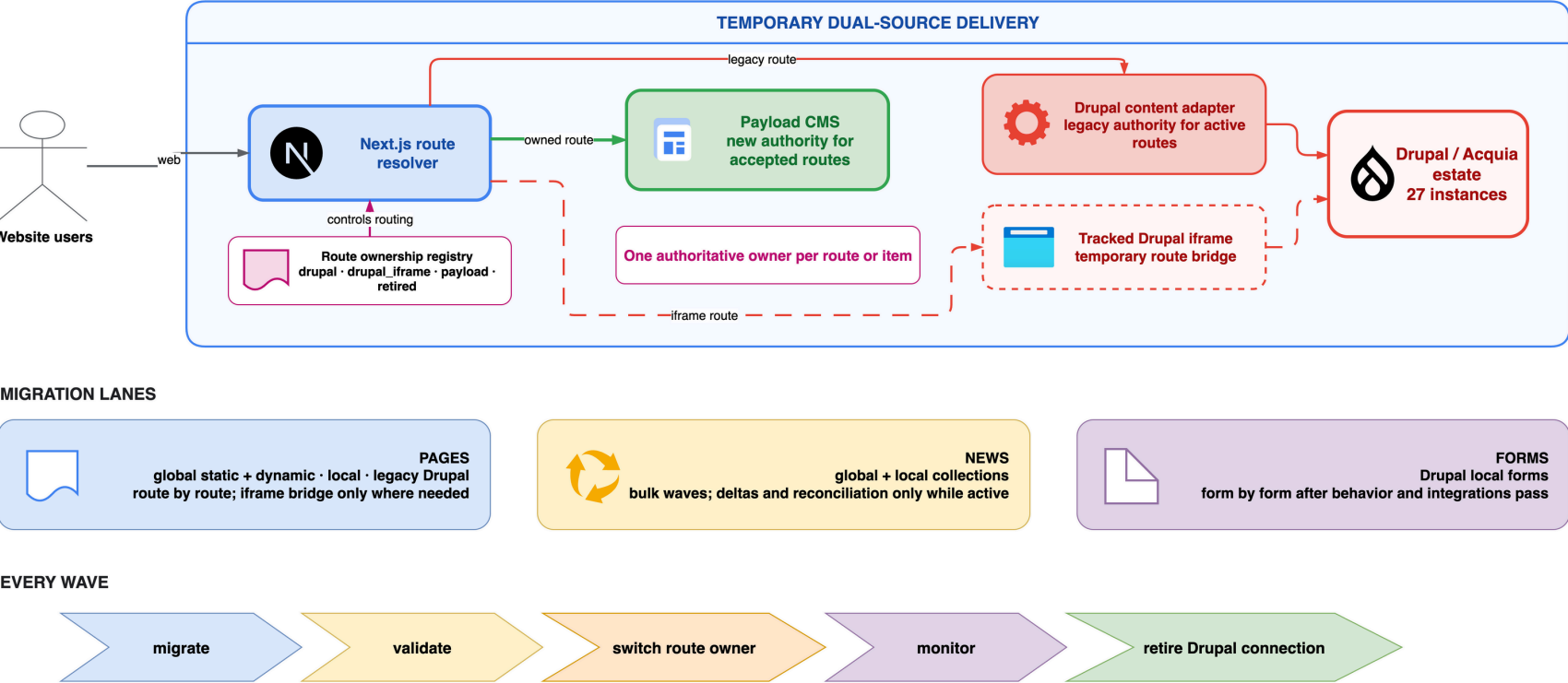


Wave-based ownership keeps delivery focused and reduces Drupal dependency after each accepted migration.

Next.js can route every page to its current owner during migration

Coexistence: Next.js serves both CMSs while ownership moves in waves

Pages, news, and forms use the lightest safe migration method; each accepted wave retires its Drupal connection.



Frontend coexistence does not mean dual editing: rollback changes route ownership; it never reverse-syncs content.

One accountable owner per route or item · temporary iframe bridge · selective updates · connection retirement by wave

Protect content fidelity during cutover; simplify after each route is stable

Drupal source	Initial treatment	Later treatment
Structured Paragraphs	Map to approved CMS blocks	Improve mappings as models evolve
Simple static pages	Migrate individually to structured fields	Editorial refinement
Large rich-text bodies	Preserve in a controlled migration format	Normalize selectively after cutover
Global / country posts	Map site scope, language, taxonomy, and SEO	Consolidate duplicate patterns
Forms	Inventory fields and behavior	Rebuild and acceptance-test before traffic

Protect	Preserve	Govern
Apply a security allowlist and identify unsupported embeds.	Maintain links, media references, and source traceability.	All migrated content continues to use the Next.js design system.

Keep content intact during cutover. Simplify it after the route is stable and the value is clear.

Build the business case on retired duplication and total cost

Planning-horizon business case = target platform TCO + transition overlap – retired Acquia/Varnish/Drupal cost

Cost area	Payload	Directus
Core licensing	MIT-licensed core; operating costs still apply	MSCL; enterprise terms apply at our scale
Enterprise capability	Vendor quote	Vendor quote
Infrastructure	GKE + Cloud SQL + GCS + observability	Broadly similar GCP footprint
Implementation	Confirm Enterprise scope before sizing extensions	Confirm ONE-specific integration scope
Skills + operating fit	Strong alignment with React and TypeScript	Vue required for Studio extensions
Exit + renewal	Low core-license dependency	Portable data; contract usage rights matter

The business case should use vendor quotes and total cost across the approved delivery and operating horizon.

The Payload PoC will confirm readiness for implementation

PoC purpose: produce evidence on editorial outcomes, platform operations, migration safety, Enterprise capability, and commercial fit.

1. Country and language isolation under real roles.
2. Content-manager translation, live preview, trash, and restore.
3. A complex dynamic form with consent, upload, notifications, and retention.
4. GKE + Cloud SQL + GCS, logging, backup, and restore.
5. Dual-source Next.js routing, tracked iframe routes, lane-based migration, and per-wave connection retirement.
6. Upgrade safety for custom Admin and workflow code.
7. Enterprise publishing workflow and static A/B testing: roles, feedback, notifications, variant delivery, analytics, and rollback.
8. Enterprise AI demonstrated for writers, translators, editors, developers, permissions, audit, and cost control.
9. Enterprise support, SLA, security, chat channel, and commercial terms.

Evidence meets acceptance criteria → implementation plan + quantified TCO

Material gap identified → update the recommendation using Directus evidence

The PoC converts remaining assumptions into evidence for the implementation plan and business case.

Directus strengths and areas to validate

Strengths

- Two-decade product history
- Large GitHub and community adoption
- Formal Basic and Premium support
- Environment Sync, Activity Log, granular policies
- Content versions, Flows, and native AI
- Database and API neutrality

Areas to validate

- MSCL enterprise terms
- Tier and feature scope
- Renewal and long-term rights
- Vue Studio extension capability
- Headless form implementation approach
- Single-instance tenancy design

Directus provides a credible enterprise benchmark for Payload's overall fit.

Enterprise terms and evidence to confirm

Contract commitments

- Exact P1/P2 SLA and 24/7 coverage
- Named private Slack or Teams channel
- Upgrade and architecture assistance
- SSO, audit, and security scope
- Price protections and termination rights
- Self-host and license guarantees

Vendor evidence

- Current community and adoption indicators
- Directus pricing and MSCL scope
- Directus AI and custom-model scope
- Payload Enterprise AI, audit, and SLA
- Figma ownership and MIT commitment
- Comparable customer references

Enterprise agreements should define support, escalation, feature scope, and commercial protections.